Does pressing actually win football matches?

I analyzed **1,517 matches of event data** and **764 team-seasons** across Europe's big five leagues, from 2015/16 to 2023/24.

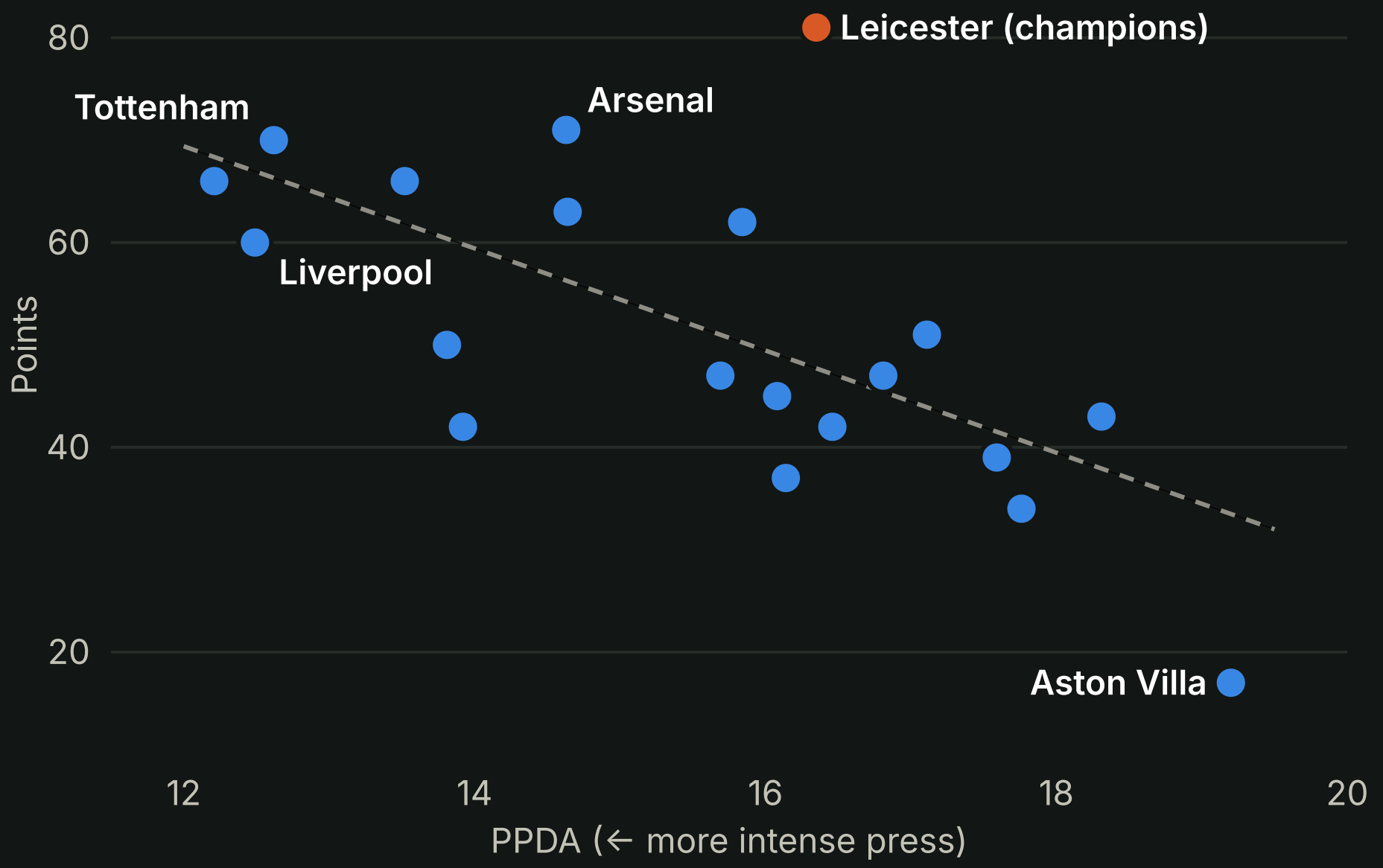
The short answer: **not the way most people measure it.**

Colin Spelman

Swipe →

At first, pressing looked like a winning formula

PPDA = opponent passes allowed per defensive action. Lower means a more intense press. In the 2015/16 Premier League, it tracked the table closely: **r = −0.65**.

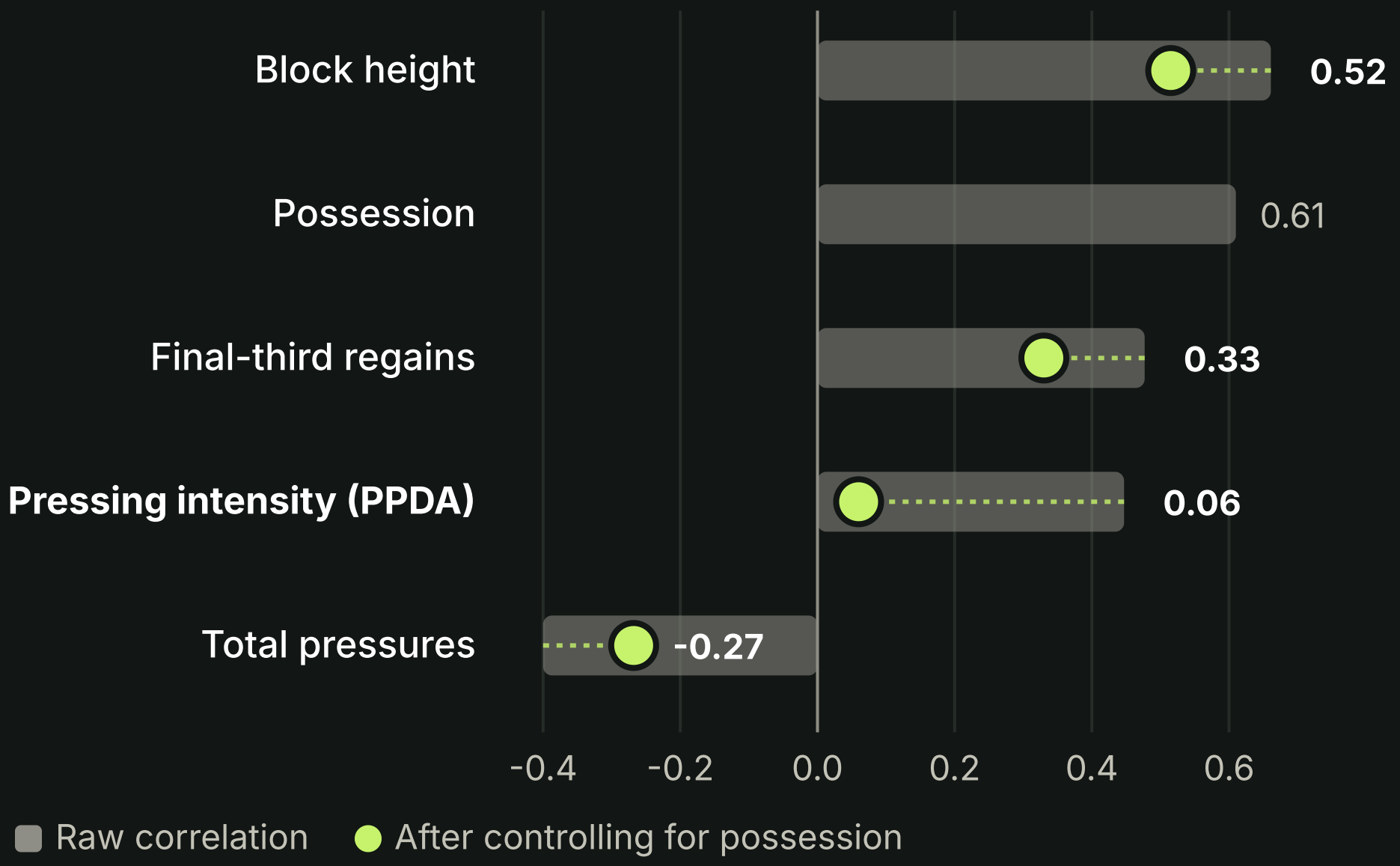


Premier League 2015/16 · 20 teams

Data: StatsBomb Open Data

Add three more leagues and control for possession, and PPDA's link to results vanishes

Teams that keep the ball face fewer passes, which flatters their PPDA. What survives is **where** a team defends.

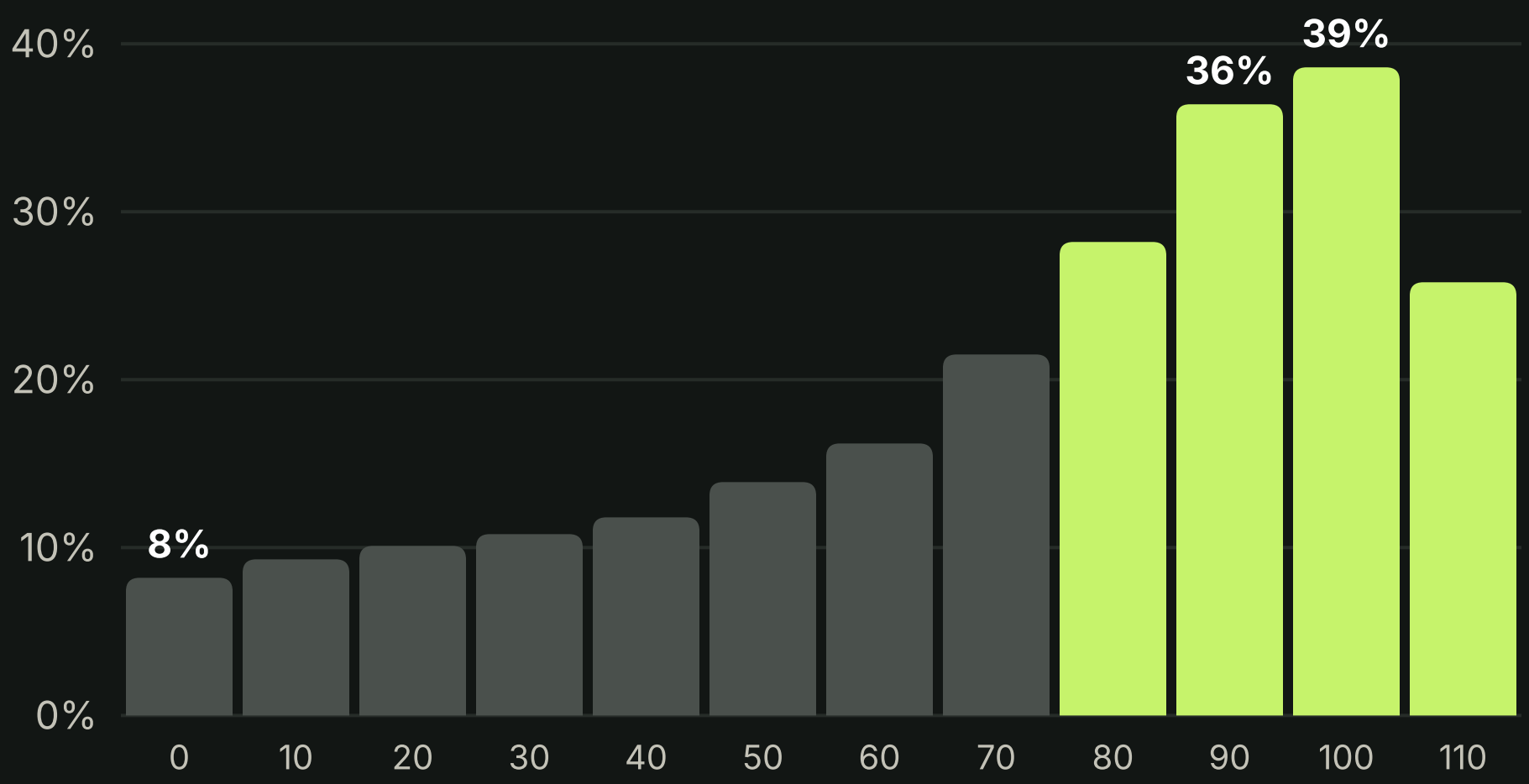


80 teams · PL, La Liga, Serie A, Ligue 1 · 2015/16

Correlation with points per game

Win the ball high and you get 3× the shots

Of possessions that began with a ball win, **31%** of those won in the final third ended in a shot, versus **10%** of those won in a team's own third.

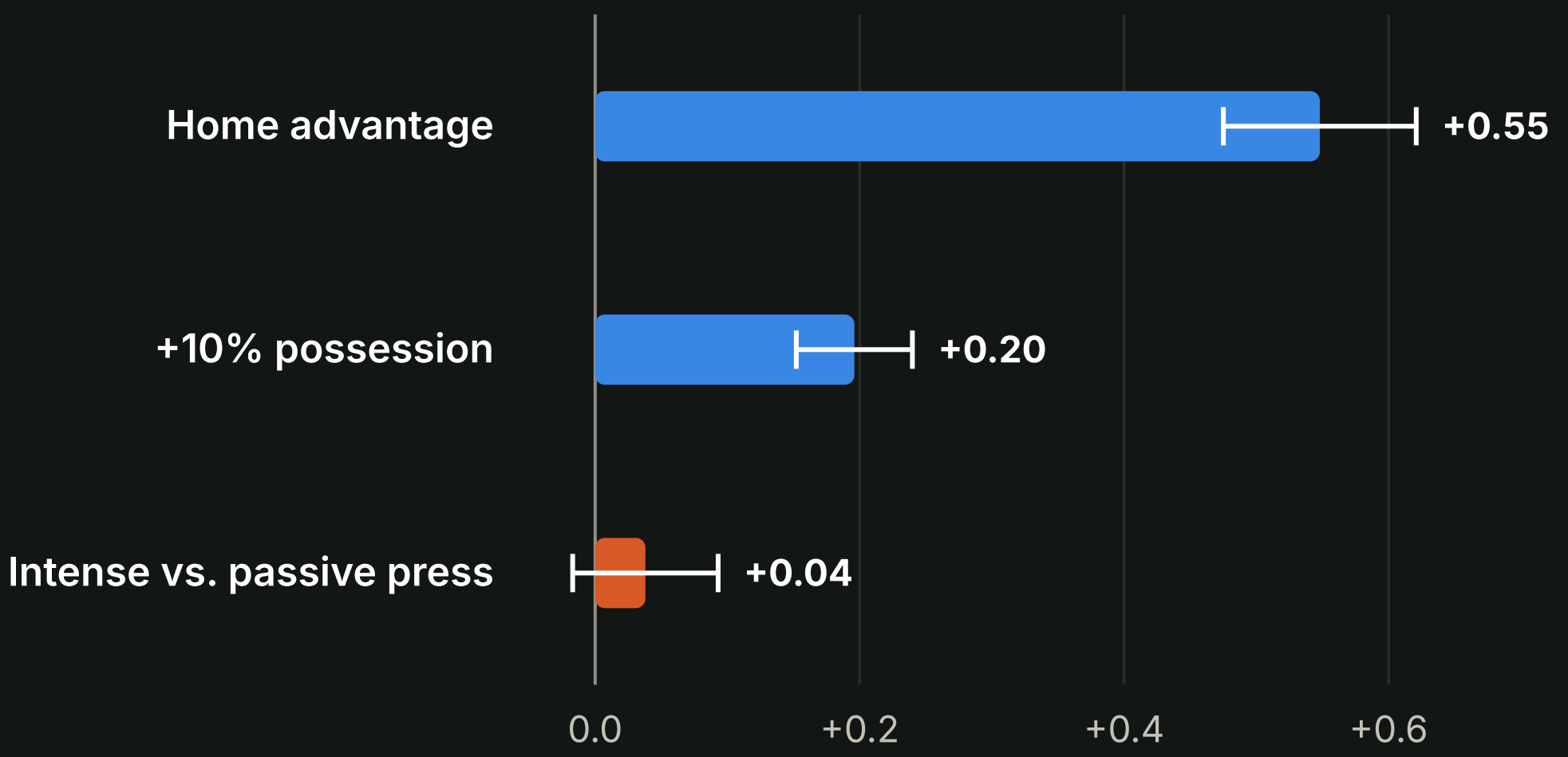


65,917 possessions · 4 leagues · 2015/16

Data: StatsBomb Open Data

Pressing harder in a given match barely moves the result

Across **2,546 team-matches**, after controlling for team quality, possession and home field, an intense press (PPDA 11) instead of a passive one (19) added just **+0.04 xG difference**, which is not statistically significant.



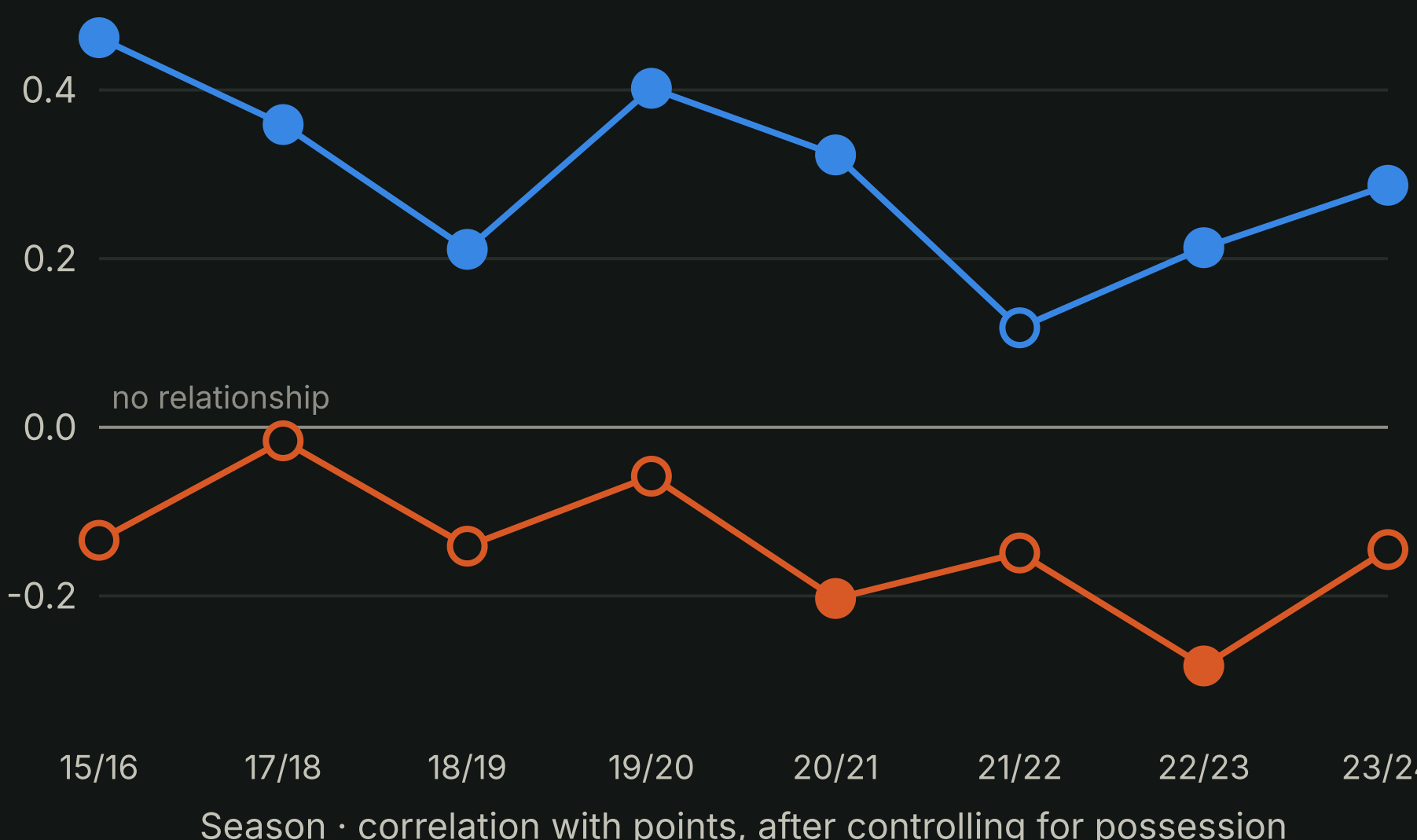
That's worth about **1 point over a 38-game season**.

Effect on xG difference per match · 95% CI shown

Data: StatsBomb Open Data

Eight seasons later, the pattern hasn't changed

After controlling for possession, **block height** was positively linked to points in every season tested. **Pressing intensity** never was.



764 team-seasons · big-five leagues

No free data for 2016/17 · StatsBomb / Opta

Compare each team to itself one season later

This removes fixed advantages like budget and squad quality. Across **505 team pairs**:

+0.05

xG difference per game when a team **raised its block height** by one standard deviation ($p < 0.001$)

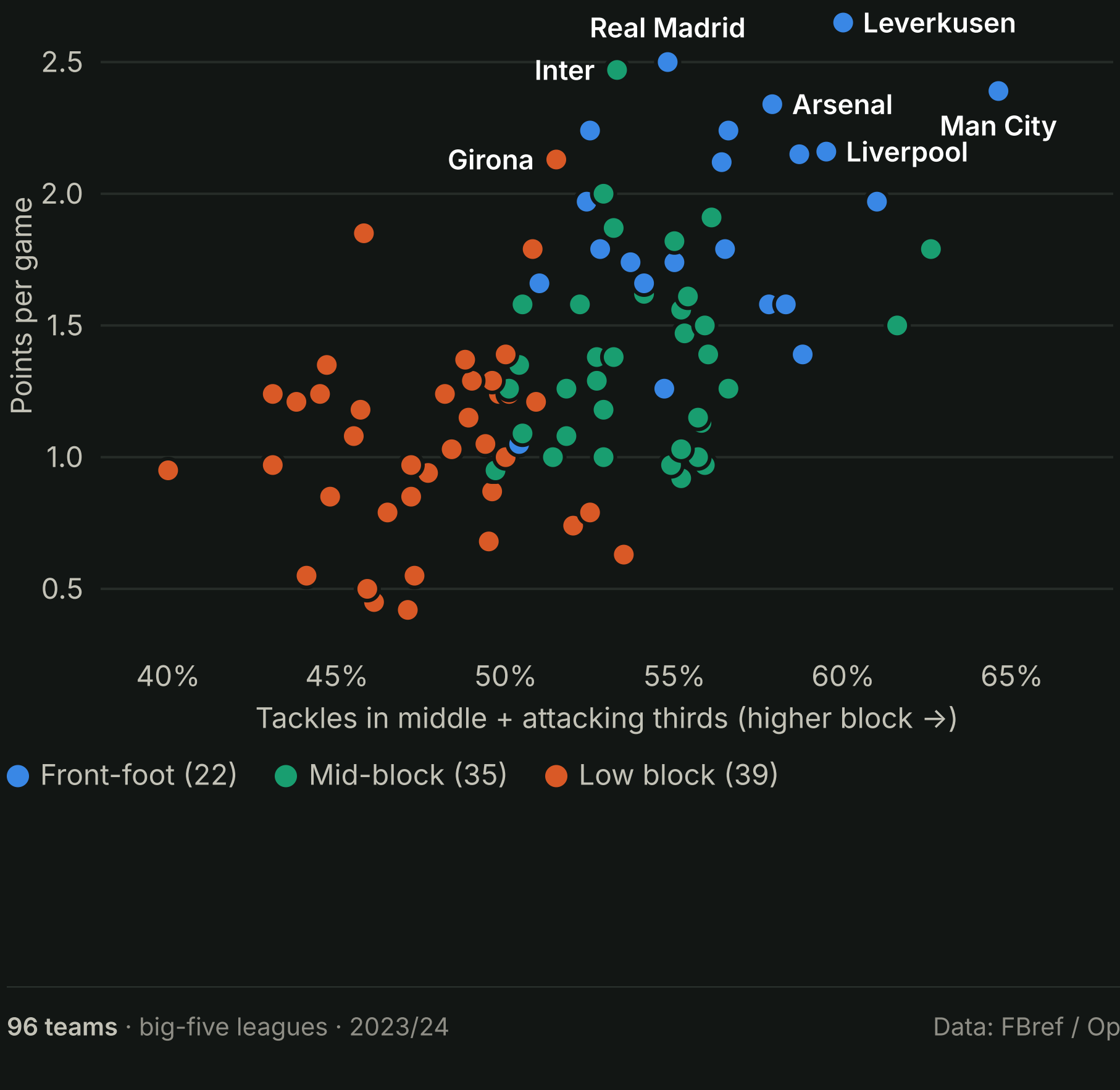
≈ 0

xG gain when a team **pressed more intensely** than the season before ($p = 0.17$)

Defending further up the pitch is the habit that travels. Chasing the ball harder isn't.

Front-foot teams dominated

Front-foot sides averaged **1.91 points per game**, vs. **1.05** for low-block teams. Four of five champions were front-foot; Inter was the exception.



You can win without a high press, but it usually means beating your xG

Leicester City

2015/16 · CHAMPIONS

13th-most-intense press in the PL

Only **43% possession**

+0.36 pts/game above their xG-based expectation, about 14 points

Girona

2023/24 · 3RD IN LA LIGA

Defended deep: **53rd of 96** for block height

Kept the ball: **57% possession**

+0.41 pts/game above expectation, 3rd-biggest in Europe

Both had strong underlying numbers, but both also beat them by a wide margin. That's hard to repeat.

Expectation = points predicted from xG difference

StatsBomb · FBref / Opta

What I'd tell a coach or analyst

1. **Don't judge a press by PPDA alone**
   It mostly reflects how much a team has the ball.

2. **Track where you win the ball**
   Final-third regains produce shots 3× as often.

3. **Block height is the repeatable edge**
   It tracks points in every season, even within the same team.

Next, I want to test this with tracking data, measuring how compact the block is, not just where tackles happen.

What would you test next?

Colin Spelman

Data: StatsBomb Open Data · FBref / Opta via worldfootballR